| MAHUA MOITRA | 49 | Trinamool Congress Leader |

Cause Celebre



CORNERED AND EXPELLED FROM PARLIAMENT SHE MAY BE, BUT THE RELENTLESS CRITIC OF THE MODI REGIME IS BY NO MEANS DONE YET

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

She's the first parliamentarian to be expelled from Parliament in almost 20 years, but Mahua Moitra has no plans to skulk silently into the night. On December 8, the day the ethics committee verdict was pronounced in the Lok Sabha in the 'cash-for-query' case, she stood outside the House and gave a fiery five-minute speech, quoting revolutionary Bengali poet Sukanta Bhattacharya and other worthies and vowed to fight the ruling BJP for "the next 30 years". With the members of the opposition INDIA alliance by her side, she raged on, accusing the saffron camp of "the most tenacious witch-hunt of one of the 78 women MPs".

In an interview preceding her expulsion, Mahua had said that when she believes in something, she "will not back down even if I am the last person standing". After some initial radio silence, her party, the Trinamool Congress (TMC), also threw its weight behind her. As proof, on November 13, the Krishnanagar MP was appointed district secretary for the Nadia-Krishnanagar organisational district. TMC party chief Mamata Banerjee is now firmly backing her. "This is a murder of democracy. Mahua is a victim of the circumstances, the party is totally behind her. She will win this battle and the people will give a befitting reply to

ACTION AND REACTION

- On December 8, Mahua was expelled from the Lok Sabha by a voice vote for "unethical conduct"
- This followed a House ethics panel report on 'cash-for-query' allegations against her
- Mahua had often been raising questions related to the Adani group's business in the House
- The allegations sought to link this to her proximity to a rival business figure; she called it 'a fixed match'